

3.2.4 WHY IT RULES

Touchscreen

The Nintendo DSi wanted to bring in a change to the way games are played, and it did so splendidly with the introduction of the touchscreen interface in the lower half of the dual screens.

The gameplay gets so innovative with this addition, and one can sense that developers relish the challenge of creating a game for the system.

The fact that the touchscreen doubles up for various other tasks, such as the PictoChat, is only icing on top of a delicious pastry. While the stylus and handwriting recognition has lost out to thumb-based touch interfaces now, the DS remains very easy and delightful to operate.

Backwards compatibility

In coming out with a new console, it is easy to ignore what you have done before. Sony made the mistake with the PlayStation 3, as a lot of consumers never upgraded to it because their collection of old PS2 titles would be rendered obsolete.

Nintendo, thankfully, avoided this mistake with the DS; in fact, it bent over backwards to make sure that the customer could use his old GameBoy cartridges by not only including a slot for it, but throwing in the GameBoy processor for games that required it.

The latest version of the console, the DSi, has phased out this GameBoy slot, but has only done so after most of the popular titles have become easily available to play through online downloads or emulators.

3.2.5 WHY IT SUCKS

Video playback

While the dual screens of the Nintendo DS brought a change in handheld gaming, they also took out any possibility of the system doubling up as a multimedia playback device.

Initially, it did not act as an MP3 player either; but the new DSi fixed that aspect, and also brought in a camera.

However, watching a movie on the handset while on-the-go remains a distant dream. In fact, even if Nintendo were to start supporting the codecs necessary for it, it would remain a horrible viewing experience because of the form factor alone.

Nintendo made a great gaming device with the DS, but it can never fill the all-round shoes of the PlayStation Portable.